▼ GLASSHOUSE



FREQUENT FLIER

Rahul Gandhi has done it again. Just as the INDIA bloc's confrontation with the Election Commission was gathering steam, its most visible campaigner reportedly flew off to Vietnam. Street protests may have been on a festive pause, but the timing gave new impetus to an old grouse: that the Congress leader goes MIA when it comes to the crunch. In 2015, for instance, with the Narendra Modi-led BJP government at the Centre still finding its feet, Rahul disappeared on a two-month sabbatical amid the battle over the Land Acquisition Bill. He chose to be out of the country again in 2019, the year of the Haryana and Maharashtra polls, and the anti-CAA protests that December. In 2025, as the battle for Bihar raged on, followed by Parliament fighting over the replacement of the rural employment guarantee, MGNREGA, Rahul was in Germany, then in Vietnam. The latter destination, in fact, seems to be a favourite, with this his third visit in the past 20 months. While his party fights on the streets, Rahul seems to be busy collecting air miles.

Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

▼ MS AND MISSING

NOTABLE ABSENCE



Actor **Mallika Sherawat**, best known for her 'bold' roles in Bollywood thrillers of the early 2000s, arrived in Patna on October 17 for a Dandiya night, but made a bigger splash with an appearance at Rashtriya Janata Dal patriarch Lalu Prasad's residence. Elder scion **Tej Pratap Yadav**, who had earlier met her on a reality show, introduced the actress to mother Rabri Devi and sister Rohini Acharya. Tej, currently embroiled in a divorce battle with wife Aishwarya Rai, looked positively radiant in the Instagram video he shared. Younger brother and Bihar Opposition leader **Tejashwi Yadav**, though, was conspicuously absent in the pictures, and social media was quick to catch on. In the Lalu household intrigues, it is often the absentees that attract more comments than those present.